Deep Editing

Table of Contents

- Introduction
- The Content Edit
  - What is its ultimate purpose?
  - What are the individual points?
  - Does every point make sense?
  - Is every point relevant?
  - Is every point worthwhile?
    - Eliminating Rambling
  - Is every point unique?
  - Are all the "facts" correct?
  - Is anything missing?
- The Structure Edit
  - What is the "angle"?
  - What are the key sections?
  - What is the narrative structure?
  - Are the points ordered elegantly?
- The Style Edit
  - Is there narrative definition?
  - Does it read well?
  - Is there any clutter?
  - Are the paragraphs in good shape?
  - Could it start better?
  - Could it end better?
  - Can we make it more evocative?
  - Is every person and entity correctly introduced?
- The Presentation Edit
  - Is the spelling, grammar, and punctuation respectable?
  - Do the headlines and text square up?
  - Is everything consistent?
  - Read out loud

Introduction

Deep editing has 4 key stages, and it's helpful to think of these stages as layers.

1. Content edit - Ask questions to help evaluate what to keep in, what to take out, and what to change. Is every point unique and different? Does everything make perfect sense? Is everything factually true? Is it relevant? And if so, Is it worth keeping?
2. Structure edit - This is where you organize the points in the writing into an orderly narrative that flows well from beginning to end.
3. Style edit - This is where you make sure that all of the ideas are expressed in a stylish way, which means as simply, clearly, elegantly, and evocatively as possible.
4. Presentation edit - This is where you tidy up the grammar, the spelling, the punctuation, typos, but also where you check for things like inconsistencies and ideas that might have gone astray during the heaviest stages of the edit.

Focus on understanding each stage of the process, not editorial choices.

Not all the editing tools have to be used in every case.

Remember that these tools are more like guidelines, and not hard and fast rules.

Read through the entire piece of writing first. Get to know the subject matter, discover the author's primary intent, get to know the author's style, and avert any fundamental misunderstandings

https://copyblogger.com/content-editing/

https://owl.purdue.edu/owl/general_writing/academic_writing/paramedic_method.html

https://www.thesaurus.com/e/grammar/what-are-the-types-of-verbs/

The Content Edit

What is its ultimate purpose?

1. What is the content actually trying to do? Informing? Persuading? Entertaining? Inspiring?
2. Who is this content aimed at?

Try to define both in the form of a concrete sentence in this kind of form:

"This article is focused on doing X-X-X for X-X-X."

First you have a go at defining the intent and the audience in that form.

Purpose: The article is aimed at informing Sri Lankans about a new government plan to label sugary drinks to help improve the nation's health.

Why is being clear on the purpose so important?

Because it's really going to help to define what is relevant and worthwhile in the article. If these two things aren't clear, it will be very difficult to decide what to keep and what to toss out, and so on. So, if you're still not clear on the intent and the audience after reading something that you're supposed to edit, you need to urgently clarify those things with the author until you get a clear view, because this is such an important step.

What are the individual points?

Discover what the individual points are that are being made in a piece of writing. Remember that most writing consists of a series of points.

I'd recommend creating a list of individual points from the article. You can do this simply by breaking it out into stand-alone sentences.

To edit anything, you need to have a clear view of everything that is being said. In the current form it's difficult to get that clear view. Only when we have lined up the points can you truly begin to evaluate them, and that's vital when you're doing a content edit.

Breaking up the points

Does every point make sense?

Making sense of each point

Is every point relevant?

Deleting irrelevant points

Is every point worthwhile?

Eliminating Rambling

Is every point unique?

Getting rid of repetition

Are all the "facts" correct?

Verifying the "facts"

Is anything missing?

Adding in missing information

Links for further review

https://www.magneticmemorymethod.com/main-points/

https://www.grammarly.com/blog/wordplay/

https://www.grammarly.com/blog/parts-of-speech/

https://www.thesaurus.com/e/grammar/what-are-the-types-of-verbs/

https://lin-tree-solver.adambcomer.com/

The Structure Edit

What is the "angle"?

The "angle" is not so much about what you are trying to achieve, but what you're going to focus on exactly. The angle is what's going to give shape to what you are going to be editing. You're going to literally hang the piece on this angle. A useful way of looking at an angle is to consider how you're going to get into the piece. It's what you're going to tell the readers immediately regarding what the piece is about. It's what you're going to focus on.

It's often the first substantive point that you're going to make in the piece of writing itself, to focus it tightly.

Look through you points and notice that there are several different angles that you could take, different ways of leding, which is a common phrase in journalism. "What's your lede?"

In asking for the lede, we're really asking for a clear angle. Because we understand that whatever you start with is almost always the most important thing.

At the moment, our opening sentence is "The Ministry of Health said it will be mandatory and enforceable from the beginning of August to display colour codes according to the sugar content percentage in all soft drinks."

Once you have chosen an angle, rally the rest of the piece's writing around that angle.

This is really the start of bringing order to the material.

Choosing your "angle".

What is it that makes an announcement newsworthy? For a publisher to consider your particular story newsworthy it must have a both strong news angle and be interesting. The news angle is your specific hook. It's the news event, the controlling issue, and the reason the news editor will want to publish your story. It should tell how it affects your industry, organization, or

community. Keep in mind, that publicity and advertising are two different things. Your news release needs tell people your story from what appears to be an unbiased third party.

Here are 10 frequently used news angles used by public relations professionals to create a story that newspapers will want to pick up:

1. New Development ? Brings forward new information to an existing story or exposes an entirely original news story.
2. Human Interest ? Relates the story to social issues or discusses a person in an emotional way, as to generate interest or empathy in the reader.
3. Local Angle ? Describes how the local community or economy will be affected.
4. Progress ? Demonstrates human innovation, positive interactions, or willingness to meet the challenge presented.
5. Consequence - Relates a group or organization to an existing news event, usually describing how it's being affected by a previous announcement or occurrence.
6. Eminence or Prominence ? Discusses emerging trends (usually informing the reader of why the trend is popular and what it means to them).
7. Conflict ? Explains a controversy often with opposing view points and positions.
8. Drama ? Describes a conflict likely to invoke an emotional response or provides an editorial of such events.
9. Disaster ?Describes the impact of negative situations (and usually either what brought them about, how it's affecting the new subject, or what's being done about it).
10. Timing and Proximity ? Relates a particular story (often warnings or advice) to a specific region or event (such as a holiday or season).

By understanding each of the press release angles, you'll be able to craft a story that is newsworthy. You should take the time to consider which of these angles is likely to create the most interest for your organization.

From [https://www.streetdirectory.com/etoday/-uuofou.html] (https://www.streetdirectory.com/etoday/-uuofou.html)

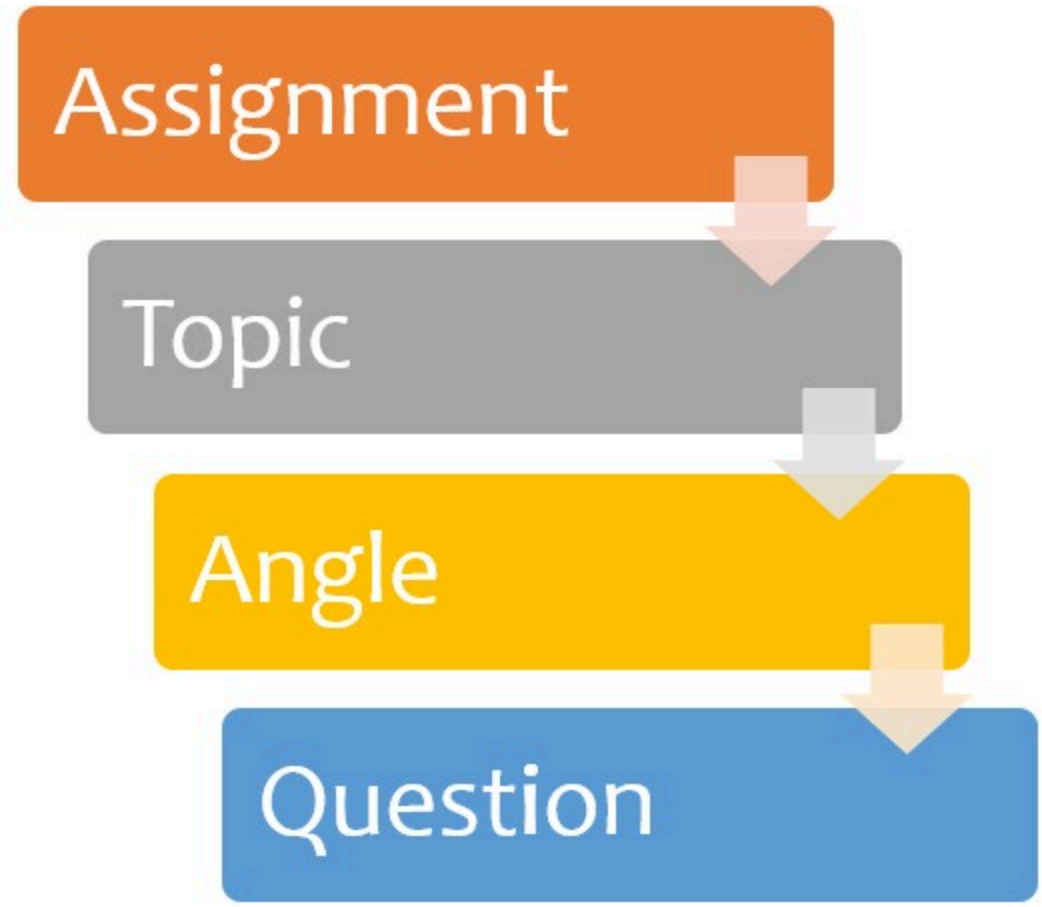
A research assignment needs more than just a topic. Research is problem-solving with information. It is more than a simple report of what is already known.

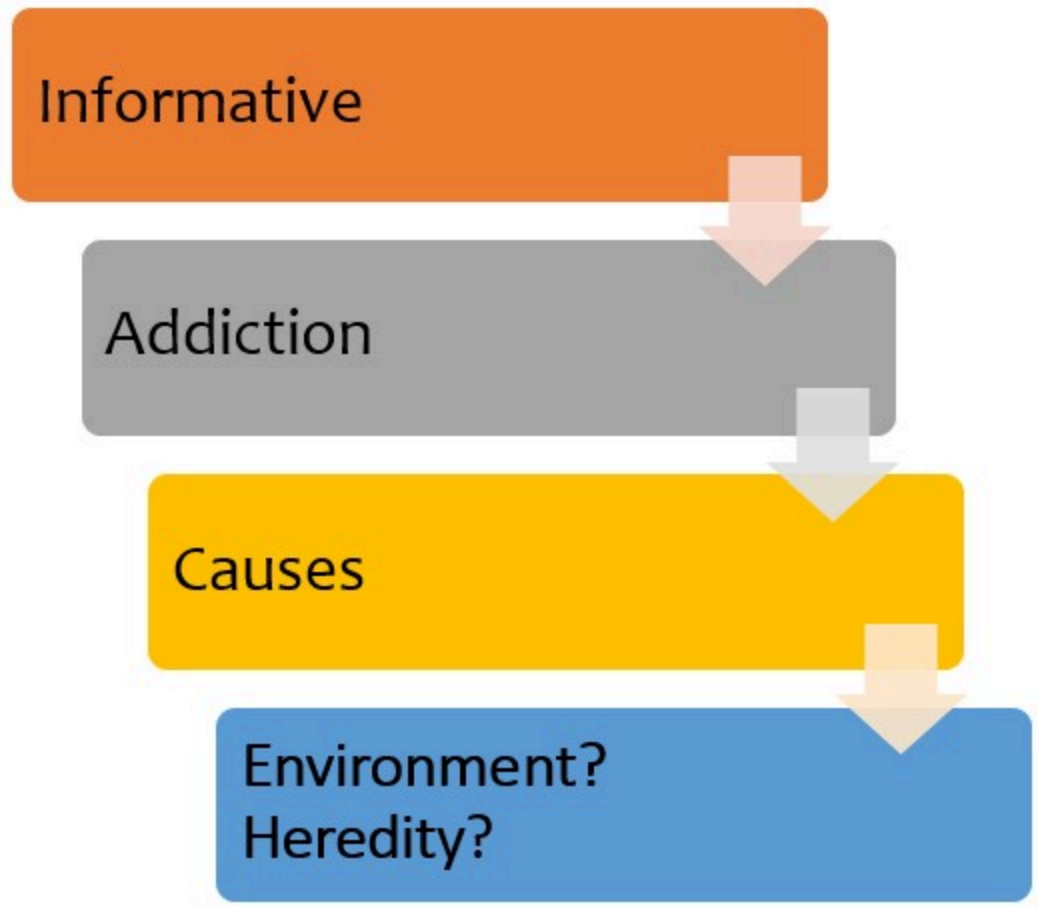
As you brainstorm a topic, you will probably find something within that topic to investigate. This is called an angle. The angle is a smaller, more specific element within the larger topic. The angles is what you will investigate with the context of the larger topic.

Once you have an angle, create a question about what you want to investigate. This research question shapes and guides your search for sources and ultimately your paper.

- Assignment: What does it require? Are there specific criteria to meet, such as informative, argumentative, or problem/solution?
- Topic: Brainstorm possible topics that fit the assignment. Consider topics you are interested in and care about
- Angle: What smaller part of the topic can you focus on? Within this big topic, what are you most curious about? (Procon.org can be a good source for thinking about angles).
- Question: Ask a question about your angle. Conduct research to find a potential answer to your question.

The process flow is illustrated in these images.





From https://library.nwacc.edu/pickatopic/angle#

So, how do you find the angle of your writing piece?

1. What are you writing about? This is the subject.

The first thing you need to determine is what your subject is. This is the broad, general idea that you are writing about. For example: the rain, getting sick, board games or long jump.

For this writing piece, I'm going to use the example: dogs pooing on nature strips.

2. What is the overlap in your content? This is the topic.

More specific than the subject is the topic you are writing about. The topic narrows the focus of your writing piece.

Continuing with the subject 'dogs pooing on nature strips', potential topics could be:

- Picking up dog poo on nature strips.
- Dog poo on nature strips affecting the environment.
- Stepping in dog poo on nature strips.

The narrower your subject, the narrower your topic. If I had gone with a broader subject, such as ‘dog poo’, my topic would also be broader. In such a case, potential topics could be:

- Dogs pooing on nature strips.
- The smell of dog poo.
- How often dogs poo.

You want to only pick one topic. If you write about the smell of dog poo, then dog poo on nature strips affecting the environment, then stepping in dog poo on nature strips, your writing piece will be difficult to follow.

If you’ve started working on your piece already, you may have lots of content. What is the one encompassing focus of your content? Are there parallels or similarities between the ideas you’ve already written about? If you can’t find any, I suggest noting the idea you have the most content for — as this is likely the one that interests you most — and finding a related topic.

If you haven’t started working on your piece yet, try writing down thoughts and ideas about your subject. Then look for any parallels or similarities. Again, if you can’t find any, pick the idea that interests you most to find a related topic.

3. What is your opinion of the overlap? This is the angle.

Once you have a topic, you need to decide your opinion of that topic. What do you want to say in your writing piece?

If the example topic chosen was ‘Picking up dog poo on nature strips’, the angle could be ‘Dog owners should pick up their dog’s poo on nature strips’.

An angle is usually an opinion. Sometimes it is informative — ‘How to pick up dog poo on nature strips’ — or a narrative — ‘The time I picked up my dog’s poo on the nature strip’ — but even then there is usually an underlying opinion. An article about ‘How to pick up dog poo’ insinuates that the writer wants you to pick up your dog’s poo.

Every good writing piece says something, even if not explicitly. By finding the angle of your writing piece, you can know what you’re saying before you say it, structure your writing so it’s easier to read, avoid writer’s block, and give your writing purpose.

From [https://ellemcfadzean.com/3-questions-to-find-your-writing-angle/] (https://ellemcfadzean.com/3-questions-to-find-your-writing-angle/)

What are the key sections?

We want to start organizing the material around the angle that we've created. It's the first real step in creating the narrative out of the currently disorganized heap of material that we're

dealing with. A narrative is something that has shape, direction, a sense of focus, and a sense of movement. It's really just the opposite of a series of randomly organized points, which is what we have at the moment.

Create a category for each point that you've got. The idea is to create a few basic categories from that can accommodate each point that we are making in the piece.

Who: government, soft-drink manufacturers

What: measures

When: latest

Where: Sri Lanka

Why: To improve the nation's health - potentially dangerous sugar levels

How: initiative - color-coded system

How much: red color, amber color, green color

Creating Categories

What is the narrative structure?

Here is where we're going to start getting some clear definition into the narrative. That basically comes about by organizing the categories that we've just selected into the best possible order.

1. WHY THE MEASURES WERE INTRODUCED
2. DETAILS OF THE NEW MEASURES
3. SOFT-DRINK MAKERS' REACTION TO THE NEW MEASURES
4. OTHER SIMILAR HEALTH INITIATIVES
5. HOW THE NEW MEASURES WILL HELP CONSUMERS

The art of editing is being able to choose an order for those categories that you feel is best for the structural edit. This is what makes for an elegant narrative.

Creating a narrative

1. LEAD: CONSUMERS WILL BE BETTER OFF THANKS TO NEW MEASURES
2. DETAILS OF THE NEW MEASURES
3. WHY THE NEW MEASURES WERE INTRODUCED
4. HOW THE NEW MEASURES WILL HELP CONSUMERS
5. OTHER SIMILAR HEALTH INITIATIVES

6. SOFT-DRINK MAKERS' REACTION TO THE NEW MEASURES

Now that we have this basic narrative structure, the next step is to place the various points into their relevant sections and categories.

You could organize the details section so that the key details come first, followed by the supporting details (below the key details).

You may even want a more complex narrative structure that, for instance, sets an idea up earlier in the piece, say, the conflict with soft-drink makers, even before you come to the section itself, which is lower down. That's what some journalists might refer to as "flicking at something high up, and then returning to it."

Once you are comfortable with the order of the section names that constitute the shape of the narrative for your piece, feel free to remove those section labels from your working copy of the narrative.

Are the points ordered elegantly?

You want to make sure that the points within each of those sections are themselves ordered elegantly. At the moment, the points in each section are just randomly placed because we just moved them into their relevant categories.

Now, you need to read through each section and start placing the points in the best order. You want to make sure that all the points within the sections are neatly organized to flow nicely into each other.

Place the points within each section in their best order so that they begin to look as though they would in a proper piece of writing. Don't worry about making the sentences themselves sound better at this point. That comes later, in the Style edit. Keep all of the points within their categories, but rearrange them so that they flow better into each other.

Ordering points within sections

Keep in mind that, even after completing this step, it is likely that the narrative itself still won't read that well. But the infrastructure will be solid. The different parts give shape to the narrative. It gives you a great basis to go on and define that shape even better. The points now have an orderly feel to them.

The narrative is now ready for you to work with in terms of making it read well and giving it a bit of style.

It's really important to understand that, without this structural edit, it's very difficult to bring style to a piece of writing, because it's not orderly at its core. This is the step that most people don't understand.

Unless the structure is there and the elegant organization of categories and the elegant placement of points within categories is there, there is no point in playing around with the style of the piece. This is because it's not going to have the basis to create stylish writing upon.

The Style Edit

Is there narrative definition?

The first thing that you need to think about here is narrative definition. This is a very useful style aspect.

Remember how you placed all the points into sections? Now you want to make sure that the reader gets the narrative turns that lead into each of the sections. Create a narrative turn to introduce each of the new sections. This isn't necessarily a hard-and-fast rule that you always have to use. What follows is just things that you can do, so that you're empowered to employ any of these techniques as you wish.

Each narrative turn should be tied in with the angle in order to infuse the piece with a sense of cohesion as it moves along.

The term "narrative turn" was apparently coined by Martin Kreiswirth.

Look at https://wp.wwu.edu/f18practicum/2018/11/27/narrative-turns-in-writing-studies-research/

"Narrative Turns in Writing Studies Research" by Debra Journet

https://static1.squarespace.com/static/63c8361892ae3916d128e35d/t/64ca9ea39285da78dca5f738/1691000483972/

https://books.openbookpublishers.com/10.11647/obp.0187/tables.xhtml

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Category:Promotion_and_marketing_communications

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Category:Propaganda_techniques_using_words

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Category:Media_manipulation_techniques

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Category:Propaganda_techniques

https://blog.p2pfoundation.net/78-questions-to-ask-about-any-technology/2019/02/26

Creating narrative "turns"

Does it read well?

Now, you will be taking a look at the language itself. Above all, focus on making things sound straightforward and clear. You want to bring simplicity, clarity, and elegance to a piece of writing. First of all, that means avoiding any unnecessarily formal words and pompous language. You want to phrase things in plain English and in the simplest way possible. Remove any unnecessary jargon, really technical words, meaningless abstractions to do with any awkward phrasings. Make each point as succinct as possible, using as few words. Remember to be economical with your words.

Making the piece read well

Is there any clutter?

The next stage of the style edit is to dispose of any needless clutter that's in the piece. These are things like pointless acronyms, pointless quotations, quotation marks over phrases, overdone names and titles, unnecessary capitalizations, etc. We want to eliminate anything that disrupts the flow of ideas, so that the piece starts to read more stylishly. Ask yourself "Do I really need this?" for each of these items. This is about improving the reading experience.

Clearing up the clutter

Are the paragraphs in good shape?

Knowing how to create nice paragraphs can add a layer of style to your writing instead of making each point its own sentence. You can begin to bunch points together to create a nicer reading experience. It is also important to focus on maximizing comprehension ("Does this help make the piece easier to understand?") and maximizing the elegance ("Does this help make the piece flow better?"). Put the points together in a way that makes the reading experience better overall.

Arranging paragraphs

Could it start better?

One way to style up a piece of writing is to give it a cool opening. This won't work for all types of writing that you have to edit. You have to use your judgement to decide whether you want a straight intro or something a little cooler or jazzier.

A simple way to style up the into is to go anecdotal. An anecdote is a colorful story about a real incident or a real person, but the anecdote must take us straight into the angle. Otherwise, you're just wasting time and rambling.

So, the trick is to think about the angle first, and let that suggest an anecdote to you. What would it suggest you do? What kind of story would ease us into the lede nicely?

A reminder of the lead:

Sri Lankans will be able to make healthier choices about what to drink, after new measures forcing beverage makers to reveal potentially dangerous sugar levels in their products.

The obvious thing may be an anecdote about a person who has some kind of sugar-related illness, who perhaps wishes he'd known how bad these sugar-loaded drinks can be for you.

So, you are looking for an anecdote that leads into the introduction. It should be short and to the point, but it should dramatize the opening in a way that makes it jazzier or interesting. Again, this is not something that's going to be appropriate for every kind of writing. But, if you see an opportunity and it's appropriate, you want to be able to choose an anecdote that fits with the angle or dramatizes the angle in some way. It's very important to pay attention to that. It's got to be closely related to the angle.

Creating a jazzy intro

Could it end better?

The other way of styling up a piece of writing is to end it with a flourish. It's always worth considering whether you can jazz up the ending in some way. Endings can aim to round off a piece of writing beautifully. It can give it a sense of completeness, and often that means returning to the initial idea of the piece in some way, or at least to the focal point of the piece.

Our focal point all along has been the angle of Sri Lankans being better able to manage their health, thanks to these changes that the government's bringing in.

You may want to return to the same anecdote you have in the beginning (Ravi's story).

Creating a snazzy ending

Can we make it more evocative?

You want to consider whether you can make the piece come alive a little bit more. It's what makes the difference between a dry piece of writing and something that's more colorful. This is done mainly with imagery and evocative and lively words, replacing other ones that are less so. You don't want to overdo this, or it'll look cheap. Just throw in a bit of evocative language where possible to add life and color to it. Look for places where you can change dry, technical words into more colorful words.

Adding color to the narrative

Is every person and entity correctly introduced?

A big source of untidiness in writing are when people, organizations, and other entities are introduced poorly. This definitely affects the style of the writing in a bad way.

Tidy references

The Presentation Edit

Is the spelling, grammar, and punctuation respectable?

The Presentation Edit is sometimes referred to as the Copy Edit, or even Proofreading.

The Presentation Edit is about "dotting the I's and crossing the T's", as they say, and that's a kind of specialized skill in itself. You can go into very deep levels of this. Some people are hired just to do that. We're not going to go that deep. But the chances are that you probably don't have that kind of specialized knowledge for proofreading as such, and strictly you don't have to have it, especially when you're just doing an edit. As long as you can make it good enough.

But the grammar, punctuation, and spelling does have to be to what I would call a respectable standard. You can't be sloppy about it. You have to do your best, and you have to know the basics.

In this section, we're going to focus on the Presentation, which includes all of what I've just talked about. It's the final thing that you can do to make whatever you're editing look really slick.

Taking care of the basics

- Commas
- Semicolons
- Parentheses
- Hyphenation
- Quotation marks
- Additional spaces
- Etc.

Do the headlines and text square up?

- Look closely at whether all of your headings, subheadings, and so on match up with each other.
- Make sure that each of the headings and subheadings are in sync with the text that they are introducing.
- In the context of what you are writing, decide whether the main heading does a good job of focusing the material or not.

Alternative headlines to 'IN THE PINK OF HEALTH'

1. NEW SUGAR RULES TO BOOST HEALTHIER LIFESTYLES
2. TRAFFIC-LIGHT RULES TO TACKLE DIABETES SCOURGE

Title matching

Remember that subheadings are a tool that can help to liven up a piece and make it more interesting, or to organize it for better comprehension.

Alternatively, you could pull out something interesting from the text that follows the subheading.

You could also have the subheadings play on a theme, using a metaphor or something.

Is everything consistent?

- Is there a "house style" that you have been asked to follow?
- Look at bold, italics, caps, underlining, and so forth. Are we keeping these things consistent in terms of style.
- Are symbols used explicitly in the text, or are those symbols actually spelled out as words?
- Are numbers used explicitly in the text, or are those numbers actually spelled out as words?
- Be mindful of vertical and horizontal spacing between elements as well.
- Decide whether to use US spelling or UK spelling.
- Check all calculations and quantities mentioned in the piece for accuracy.

Fixing inconsistencies

Read out loud